willing to take part in such projects. Unskilled labourers from India, most of them ethnic Nepalese, were brought in and, when the work was over, many of them decided to settle in villages inhabited by their kinsmen in the south.

But the extent of illegal immigration in the south did not become evident until the authorities conducted a nationwide census in 1988. The thought was to enforce the new Citizenship Act, enacted in 1985 and meant to clarify the 1958 Act by stating that only immigrants whose families had settled in Bhutan before 1958 were entitled to citizenship. The operation turned out to be a disaster. First, it was conducted thoroughly only in the south. Secondly, it was discovered that there were many more illegal immigrants than expected all over the southern districts.

The problem was especially evident in the Samtse (previously Samchi) district in southwestern Bhutan, which can be reached by car only from India, as most Bhutanese roads lead from the border with India in south to the Bhutanese interior in the north, with only one major east–west highway through the country. Further, Samtse is adjacent to Kalimpong, one of the worst hit areas of the 1986–8 agitation, which sometimes took a violent turn, for the establishment of an autonomous Nepalese region in northern India to be called Gorkhaland. Not surprisingly, the census showed that the population of Samtse had doubled during the 1980s. According to a brochure published by the Bhutanese government: ‘The recently completed cadastral survey of Samchi [Samtse] district [also] revealed that the total illegal landholdings there was 47,235 acres, which is more than the total landholdings in Tashigang, the country’s largest district.’[39]

The exact number of ethnic Nepalese residing legally and illegally in the country in the late 1980s is not known, but it could have been as many as 30–40 per cent of the population, then stated at 1.37 million. The response was a campaign to drive out all ‘illegal immigrants’. Along with Dzongkha and English, Nepali used to be one of the three official languages of Bhutan taught in the country’s schools. But in 1989, Nepali was dropped from school curricula, and ceased to be an official language.

Some Lhotshampas responded in 1990 by forming the Bhutan People’s Party (BPP), which resisted the driglam namzha policies and said it was fighting for the rights of the people of the south. The BPP accused the government of arresting, torturing, and murdering many Lhotshampas suspected of indulging in anti-royal activities. In turn, the Bhutanese